Worksheet 3: When NOT to Use "THE"

Stopping the "I go to THE school" Habit for Italian Speakers

The Italian Trap: In Italian, you almost always use an article before places, general concepts, and languages (*"Vado a la/alla scuola", "Mi piace il caffè", "Parlo l'inglese"*). In English, we **drop "the"** when talking about places for their main purpose, general things, meals, and languages!

1. Quick Reference: Drop "THE" in These 4 Situations

Category	Common Mistake	Correct English
Places (Main Purpose) *school, work, home, bed, church*	~~I go to the school.~~ ~~He is at the work.~~	**I go to school.** **He is at work.**
General Things (Plural / Uncountable)	~~I love the pizza.~~ ~~The dogs are friendly.~~	**I love pizza.** **Dogs are friendly.**
Languages & School Subjects	~~I study the English.~~	**I study English.**
Meals *breakfast, lunch, dinner*	~~We have the dinner at 8.~~	**We have dinner at 8.**

2. Exercise A: "THE" or Nothing (Ø)?

Write **the** or **Ø** (nothing) in each blank.

1. My kids go to _____ school at 8:00 AM.
2. I'm tired. I'm going to _____ bed.
3. Pass me _____ salt, please! (*specific salt on the table*)
4. _____ Italian food is famous all over the world.
5. She speaks _____ Spanish and _____ French.
6. What time do you usually have _____ lunch?

3. Exercise B: Correct the Sentences

Cross out the unnecessary **the** in each sentence (one sentence is already correct!).

1. I go to the work by train every morning.
2. The life is beautiful when you are on vacation.
3. Can you close the door, please?
4. We are learning the English together.

4. Exercise C: Translate from Italian

1. Vado a casa adesso. → _____
2. Mi piace molto la musica. → _____
3. Lui è a lavoro. → _____

Answer Key

Ex A: 1. Ø | 2. Ø | 3. the | 4. Ø | 5. Ø, Ø | 6. Ø

Ex B: 1. I go to work... | 2. Life is beautiful... | 3. Correct! (specific door) | 4. We are learning English...

Ex C: 1. I'm going home now. | 2. I really like music. | 3. He is at work.